



# ***Rethinking the Meanings of Algeria Youth Political Participation in the Digital Age: Opportunities for Mobilization or Risks of Misinformation? -A Survey Study on a Sample of University Students-***

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## ***Abstract***

*This study seeks to shed light on the new meanings and implications of political participation in societies in light of the knowledge explosion and technological development among Algerian youth in general, and students in particular. This is evident in the increasing use of social media platforms and the increasing messages broadcast and disseminated through them, particularly with regard to promoting/weakening the values of citizenship and active participation in various community activities.*

*The study adopted a descriptive and analytical approach, relying on a questionnaire as a method within the survey methodology. This is a method of data collection that aims to systematically and uniformly motivate participants to present specific facts and opinions related to a specific topic. This is to identify indicators and implications of political participation among Algerian youth in the digital age, particularly in light of the rapid spread and use of social media among Algerian students.*

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## 1. *Introduction*

Technological advancements and the knowledge explosion have played a significant role in achieving a qualitative leap in the media and communication, to the point that we are now facing a turning point in events where change is the only constant. The Internet is no longer just the most widespread means of communication, but due to globalization and its extensions, it has also become a means of education, research, and media. The world now lives under the name of the global village, which has changed many equations and terms, and we are now living in the cyber age, accompanied by a radical shift in the balance of power, where individuals interact behind screens around the world with the click of a button and using a variety of emojis.

These transformations have resulted in the birth of what is known as social networking sites, with their various forms of interaction. These sites are now viewed with serious consideration, having captured a significant amount of attention due to their close connection to the daily lives of individuals and their endless and ongoing impact on their values and behaviors. They have become the driving force behind their attitudes and the events taking place around them, and have even permeated their thinking and the extent of their sense of belonging and societal duties, particularly during electoral periods. It is no exaggeration to say that they have, on many occasions, become the arbiter and center for making decisions, even fateful ones.

### ***Problem statement***

In light of the technological revolution sweeping the media and communications industry, social media has become a key player in modulating opinions and policymaking, in addition to its pivotal role in shaping societal awareness among individuals, particularly in influencing university students, who represent a significant segment of Algerian society. In light of all these transformations, voices are rising calling for research and questioning the new implications of political participation in the digital age. These transformations are now impacting young people, guiding their civic practices, choices, behaviors, and even their interaction with the content disseminated through them, especially in light of the spread of misleading and false information. From this perspective, the problem of this study revolves around:

**How does the digital age, with its interactive and dissemination features, contribute to rethinking and reshaping the meanings of political participation for Algerian youth, especially university students, in light of the growing opportunities for mobilization and the increasing risks of misinformation?**

### ***Research Hypothesis***

To answer the main question and its sub-questions, the following hypotheses were formulated:

**H01:** Social media platforms have a significant impact on students' opinions and behaviors regarding societal issues.

**H02:** Political participation is related to fulfilling duties and engaging in community activities.

**H03:** There are no significant differences in the impact of the digital age on the political participation of Algerian students.

### **Research Objectives**

This study seeks to achieve a set of objectives, summarized as follows:

- An attempt to understand how the new era, with its digital media, influences university students' opinions and attitudes toward societal issues;
- Determining how students use social media, the extent of their response to digital content, and how they interact with it;
- Understanding individual differences in the reception of media messages among students, and how these messages affect them based on gender, educational level, age, ...etc.
- Enhancing students' critical awareness to understand the roles and influence of digital media, and to become participants in it, rather than merely consumers, enabling them to distinguish between misleading and accurate information;
- Encouraging students to participate actively in society by deepening their understanding of the importance of their citizenship and the threats they face in cyberspace.

### **Study methodology**

In constructing this study, the researcher relied on the questionnaire tool as a technique of the survey method, which is a method for collecting data that aims to stimulate the respondents in a systematic and standardized way to present certain facts and opinions related to a specific topic.

### **Study population**

The study population consists of a random sample of students across Algerian universities. The research population was chosen based on the specificity of the study, as a large group of students are exposed to media, especially digital media, and its impact on their behavior has become prominent, especially with the

increasing number of social media platforms that have shortened distances and eliminated barriers in all their forms, changed ideas and beliefs, and even attempted to destabilize constants through the interventions of hidden hands. From here, the real impact is inevitably evident, with varying degrees from one person to another.

### **Research Design**

The study will use a quantitative research design utilizing a survey approach. The survey will be administered to a random sample of Algerian students.

The study was conducted during the period from April, 2025 to May, 2025 participants the study population consisted of a random sample of the Algerian students, and the study sample was determined, 53 students from different stages. Students are often face challenges especially with the increase of the uses of social media and the huge influence on their attitude and ideas, which need to be identified and analysed and measured.

## **2. The Theoretical Foundation of Study Variables**

### **2.1 Political Participation**

Salisbury discusses various definitions of political participation, highlighting conceptual and practical differences, ranging from the restrictive to the broader (which includes various behaviors aimed at influencing public decisions in a social context). He emphasizes the active, social, and inclusive nature of political participation, similar to the definition of Verba and Nee, who define political participation as "activities undertaken by

ordinary citizens that aim, in one way or another, directly to influence the choices and/or actions of government officials." This excludes ceremonial support and community engagement not aimed at influencing government, as well as protests or unusual methods of action (Salisbury, 1975, P326 )

It is essential to adopt methods to influence political decisions. This is where the importance of political participation becomes apparent. Despite the societal transformations taking place, it must remain present in all its forms, whether real or online, public or covert, direct or indirect. If we agree that participation is rooted in specific social contexts and characteristics, we consider it a profound and authentic political act. It should not be limited to voting.

It has been emphasized that traditional forms of political participation, such as voting and political party membership, cannot keep pace with the modern dynamics of political participation that have emerged through social media platforms. That being said, traditional offline political participation is still an important measure, prioritized in such prestigious national surveys as American National Election Studies. After all, voting, the essence of offline political participation, is the most prominent feature of liberal democracy we live in now.

To summarize, offline and online political participation may present complementing, yet different aspects and it would be beneficial to measure both to capture a holistic picture of political participation. Therefore, we included both online and offline political participation as

separate dependent variables in our study (Min, Wohn, 2018, P 07).

From another side, Yerkebulan proposed a new definition for political participation, and suggest that Political participation is any action by citizens that is intended to influence the outcomes of political institutions or their structures, and is fostered by civic engagement (Yerkebulan, 2020, P 124). We can conclude from this definition that actions are considered political participation if they aim to affect political institutions or their structures and includes both online and offline activities if they meet these criteria. It also distinctly separates political participation from civic engagement, with the latter being social activities that do not necessarily aim to influence political outcomes but can foster political participation.

## ***2.2 Internet political participation***

Internet political participation refers to political participation of citizens on the Internet. This concept is introduced by Castells (1996). This is a behavior and process to influence policymaking within the political system, using Internet to express citizens' political will and participating in political activities. Through the Internet, citizens have more opportunities understand what the government is doing and how to express their views timely to take part in the policymaking process in different ways (Weng, 2018, P61).

Rapidly developing Internet technology as a channel for political participation of citizens has created a very different political environment than in the past. As a kind of responsiveness, the use of information and communication



technology as a way of networked communication has impelled governments to transform the future model of public governance.

To understand how online political participation works, we find that individual emotions and interests, rather than general political philosophies, are the primary forces driving individuals in the digital space. The concept of political participation resembles what Schudson in 1998 called "citizenship surveillance," where citizens survey the information environment rather than acquire it in a way that makes them attentive to a wide range of issues. This can then translate into a pattern of active engagement on specific issues in a variety of ways (Min, Wohn, 2018, P 07).

### 2.3 Digital Age

In traditional interpretations, technological development is an autonomous or "natural" force with an irresistible influence on society, but itself independent of the influence of social forces. Social change consists of mere adaptation, formal education is "vocational" training in the productive use of new technologies, and opposition to social change in the direction determined by new technologies is not only "wrong" but also futile. Social change is selectively imposed as necessary and constraining: we must be prepared and ready to update ourselves, our attitudes, competencies, lifestyles, etc (Stocchetti, 2020, p 02) .

The term "digital age" is defined as the period in the course of human history that is shaped by digital information and communication technologies. Is thus the period in which digital change through digitalization and digital transformation

has progressed so far that digital technologies have a formative influence on people's lives. The term "Digital Information Age" is used synonymously (Lengsfeld, 2019, pp 25-28).

In this digital age, new concepts are shown as **Networked Society** which Describes the interconnected nature of cities and communities across the world, these hyper-connected cities where all discussions are conducted through technology using software, computers, and the internet (Nayar, 2010, p284).

This has enhanced the emergence of **Social interaction Platforms** which refer to the services provided on the Internet through which individuals can add personal information, chat, and communicate. These sites are also considered part of the social public space (Nayar, 2010, p284).

### 2.4 Political participation in the digital age

Political participation in the age of social media is different from this of the offline world, because it's supported by the norm of individual self-expression and take place in much more anonymous and comfortable settings.

The concept of political participation also requires a revamp in the social media age. The participatory landscape in today's social media boasts unique characteristics that warrant close examination. First, individuals today tend to participate in more specialized, personal, and value-laden lifestyle issues where political participation has become more event-driven and protest-like (Min, Wohn, 2018, P 07)

The digital age offers broader opportunities for political participation across a variety of digital channels and

platforms, such as social media platforms, blogs...etc. Bimber and others gave a wide perception to understand how these platforms operate in the digital age and their influence on political participation of youth. Here a number of factors, including (Bimber et al, 2014, Pp 02-09):

✓ **Opening channels of dialogue to facilitate political participation**

Social interaction platforms allow even those not involved in politics to express their opinions and aspirations. They provide fertile ground for political discussions, particularly given the ease of interaction, thereby overcoming traditional barriers and disseminating the experience to various segments of society.

✓ **Impact on Voting and Traditional Election Campaigns**

In the context of election campaigns, voting procedures, and elite behavior and orientation, frequent use of the internet to gather political information and follow the news increases voter turnout, particularly among those classified as less interested. These effects increase over time.

✓ **The Ability to Direct Votes in Modern and Innovative Election Campaigns**

Unlike what was common under traditional campaigns, where votes were mobilized through rallies, streets, seminars, and forums, today we are faced with a different form of mobilization, where votes and endorsements are gathered online, particularly through social media platforms. These platforms enable voter

surveys, information gathering, news monitoring, and behavioral influence. These effects may increase over time.

✓ **Rapid Diffusion and Diversity**

In the digital space, disseminating political discussions and discourse has become easier and more convenient. It allows all individuals to express their opinions without discrimination, especially those less interested in politics or minorities, thus expanding the scope of political participation for all citizens.

✓ **Changing Dynamics**

With the increasing prevalence of digital media and the penetration of social media platforms into people's daily lives, it has become impossible to predict the prevailing societal contexts, with their impact varying across election years and even behaviors.

**3. Redefining Political Participation in the Age of Social Interaction: A Field Study on a Sample of University Students**

**3.1 Presentation the Study Data**

The study population consisted of a random sample of Algerian students, and 53 male and female students were enrolled, here the analysis of the data: Table 01 shows the demographic characteristics of the sample.

**Table 01: Demographic characteristics of participants (n =53)**

|                 |                                                             |            |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| Gender          | Male                                                        | 18 (34%)   |
|                 | Female                                                      | 35 (66%)   |
| Age             | From 18 to 20 years                                         | 17(32.1%)  |
|                 | From 20 years 25 years                                      | 31(58.5)   |
|                 | More than 25 years                                          | 5(9.4%)    |
| Institution     | Ibrahim Sultan Cheibout (Algiers university 3)              | 42(79.25%) |
|                 | Abu Al-Qasim Saadallah University (University of Algiers 2) | 5(9.43%)   |
|                 | Morsli Abdullah University (Tipaza)                         | 4(7.55%)   |
|                 | Muhammed Bougara University (Boumerdes)                     | 2(3.77%)   |
| Academic stages | Bachelor                                                    | 26 (49.1%) |
|                 | Master                                                      | 26 (49.1%) |
|                 | PhD                                                         | 1 (1.9%)   |

Table 02 shows the indicators of social media use by the study sample

**Table 02: the indicators of social media use by the study sample (n =53)**

|                                                                                                             |                        |            |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|------------|
| What social media platforms do you follow regularly?<br>Multiple-answer question                            | Facebook               | 37 (69.8%) |
|                                                                                                             | Twitter                | 4 (7.5%)   |
|                                                                                                             | Instagram              | 43 (81.1%) |
|                                                                                                             | Telegram               | 30 (56.6%) |
|                                                                                                             | WhatsApp               | 26 (49.1%) |
|                                                                                                             | Viber                  | 4 (7.5%)   |
|                                                                                                             | Snapchat               | 23 (43.4%) |
| How many hours per day do you spend using social media?                                                     | Less than 1 hour       | 01 (1.9%)  |
|                                                                                                             | From 1 to 2 hours      | 10 (18.9%) |
|                                                                                                             | 3 to 4 hours           | 20 (37.7%) |
|                                                                                                             | More than 4 hours      | 22 (41.5%) |
| What is the main purpose of your use of social media?<br>Multiple-answer question                           | Entertainment          | 41 (77.4%) |
|                                                                                                             | Getting News           | 38 (71.7%) |
|                                                                                                             | Learning and Knowledge | 40 (75.5%) |
|                                                                                                             | Social Interaction     | 27 (50.9%) |
| Do you think that social media influences your opinions on issues and directs your behaviors and attitudes? | To a great extent      | 13 (24.5%) |
|                                                                                                             | To a moderate extent   | 29 (54.7%) |
|                                                                                                             | To a weak extent       | 11 (20.8%) |

Table 03 shows the indicators related to political participation

**Table 03: the indicators related to political participation (n =53)**

|                                                                                                                                |       |            |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|------------|
| Do you believe that you are exercising your legal rights and fulfilling your duties and responsibilities towards your country? | Yes   | 29 (54.7%) |
|                                                                                                                                | No    | 3 (5.7%)   |
|                                                                                                                                | Maybe | 21 (39.6%) |
| Did you participate in the last elections?                                                                                     | Yes   | 14 (26.4%) |
|                                                                                                                                | No    | 39 (73.6%) |
|                                                                                                                                | High  | 13 (24.5%) |

|                                                                                                                      |                       |            |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|------------|
| How knowledgeable are you about current societal issues (e.g., human rights, environment, public health)?            | Medium                | 35 (66%)   |
|                                                                                                                      | Weak                  | 5 (9.4%)   |
| How involved are you in community activities and initiatives?                                                        | High                  | 6 (11.3%)  |
|                                                                                                                      | Medium                | 15 (28.3%) |
|                                                                                                                      | Weak                  | 10 (18.9%) |
|                                                                                                                      | I never participate   | 22 (41.5%) |
| How interested are you in participating in political parties or civil society organizations to raise your awareness? | Not interested        | 25 (47.2%) |
|                                                                                                                      | Highly interested     | 6 (11.3%)  |
|                                                                                                                      | Moderately interested | 15 (28.3%) |
|                                                                                                                      | Weakly interested     | 7 (13.2%)  |

Table 04 shows the Indicators of the impact of social media on university students' political participation

**Table 04: the indicators of the impact of social media on university students' political participation (n =53)**

|                                                                                                                                   |                                     |            |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|------------|
| Do you think social media contributes to increasing your awareness of the importance of community participation in all its forms? | High degree                         | 19 (35.8%) |
|                                                                                                                                   | Moderate degree                     | 25 (47.2%) |
|                                                                                                                                   | Low degree                          | 9 (17%)    |
| Do you feel that social media promotes your sense of social responsibility and participation?                                     | High degree                         | 15 (28.3%) |
|                                                                                                                                   | Moderate degree                     | 29 (54.7%) |
|                                                                                                                                   | Low degree                          | 9 (17%)    |
| Do you think social media sites provide reliable information on political issues?                                                 | To a great extent                   | 2 (3.8%)   |
|                                                                                                                                   | To a moderate extent                | 35 (66%)   |
|                                                                                                                                   | To a weak extent                    | 16 (30.2%) |
| Do you share or post political content on social media with your friends or family?                                               | Always                              | 3 (5.7%)   |
|                                                                                                                                   | Often                               | 9 (17%)    |
|                                                                                                                                   | Sometimes                           | 12 (22.6%) |
|                                                                                                                                   | Rarely                              | 9 (17%)    |
|                                                                                                                                   | Never                               | 20 (37.7%) |
| How do you evaluate the role of social media in raising awareness of political participation among university students?           | High                                | 14 (26.4%) |
|                                                                                                                                   | Medium                              | 27 (50.9%) |
|                                                                                                                                   | Low                                 | 10 (18.9%) |
|                                                                                                                                   | None                                | 2 (3.8%)   |
| In your opinion, what are the risks of using social media in politics?                                                            | Spread of fake news                 | 20 (37.7%) |
|                                                                                                                                   | Misleading public opinion           | 22 (41.5%) |
|                                                                                                                                   | Spread of populism                  | 3 (5.7%)   |
|                                                                                                                                   | Discrimination and regionalism      | 3 (5.7%)   |
|                                                                                                                                   | Lack of oversight of biased content | 2 (3.7%)   |
|                                                                                                                                   | I see no risks                      | 00         |
|                                                                                                                                   | Others                              | 3 (5.7%)   |



### 3.2 Reading and Interpretation of the Tables

In this study, was explored the research hypotheses related to the uses of social media platforms and their influence on political participation, and discussed the potential risks associated with the rise and the expend of these platforms on Algerian students and how these risks can be mitigated through appropriate uses.

**Hypothesis 01:** Social media platforms have a significant impact on students' opinions and behaviors regarding societal issues.

The first hypothesis suggests that social media platforms significantly influence students' opinions and behaviors regarding societal issues. But before answering the hypotheses, we must first highlight the characteristics of the study sample.

By the features of the sample applied in this study, this is a heterogeneous sample since it involved students of both sexes with a dominance of females. If significant, this disparity indicates that females respond more to such surveys concerning the effect of social media and content they post, and interest in its scientific aspects related particularly to community awareness, citizenship, and political participation.

In addition, the study sample included students of various age groups, with the predominance of the 20-25 age group. This percentage may reflect the qualitative maturity of this age group in terms of their outlook on matters, especially the topic under study.

As for the statement related to the university level, there was a close convergence between the bachelor's and master's levels, which was evident in the

study sample. This can highlight the extent of this group's interest in social media platforms and their impact on society and on building their awareness, particularly in terms of political participation.

If we accept that digital presence is virtual in nature, and therefore an individual's profile, personality, and online presence depend purely on that person's choices, then, just as individuals wear "masks" in the physical world, people in the digital realm find it easier to create their own masks and convince others of their authenticity. While this poses a challenge in the physical world with personal relationships and interactions, it poses a greater challenge online. Without the aid of body language, facial expressions, and tone of voice, individuals online have a greater need to "play it smart" when it comes to evaluating their interactions (Davis, 2021, Pp 18-19). This is where social media platforms begin to create masks and distort facts to create a reality that aligns with the goals of their publishers, thus shaping opinions and ideas that may be true or false.

Based on the results of the survey, the study sample is predominantly 18-25-year old, and they spend more than four hours a day using social media platforms. This is a period sufficient to leave a lasting impact on them, especially since we are talking about a significant age group in Algerian society, namely students. It is no exaggeration to say that this impact could have a serious impact on their opinions and behaviors, particularly regarding central societal issues whose importance and sensitivity are unquestionable, such as belonging, citizenship, and participation. The results also showed that Facebook

ranked as the most used and most interacted with application by the sample, followed by other applications such as Instagram, Telegram, WhatsApp and Snapchat.

In our current age, media is considered as the primary source of information even for political data, because It provides a platform for discourse and debate, where candidates and politicians are exposed to the electors, and policies, facts are disseminated broadly. Media can also notify citizen with information to make informed choices on political issues. apart from educating citizens, media also plays the significant role of mobilizing voters and keeping those in power accountable.(Reineman, 2014, p 40).

As is well known, these applications contain news in various forms, and recently, a lot of fabricated, misleading and false content has spread, which is created using artificial intelligence features, which puts this group in the line of fire to receive and be influenced by this content, especially if we realize that the sample uses these platforms hierarchically for the purpose of entertainment, obtaining news, learning and knowledge, and social interaction. The sample also agreed at a rate of 54.7% that daily use exceeding 4 hours affects their opinions, behaviors and attitudes to a moderate degree, which leads us to say that social media platforms have a varying impact on shaping opinions and attitudes according to age groups.

**Hypothesis 02:** Political participation is linked to fulfilling obligations and engaging in community activities.

Based on the results obtained from the questionnaire, 54.7% of the study sample believe that they exercise their legal rights

and are committed to their duties towards the country, while the rest of the sample oscillates between maybe and no. In order to clarify the reasons for the sample's failure to fulfil its obligations, the answers obtained recorded differences between those who see themselves as unqualified to fulfil their duties and participate, some of whom attribute this to a lack of interest in responsibilities towards the country, and others who find no reason for their lack of interest.

From here, we notice a kind of disregard on the part of students for these responsibilities, and some of the answers we classify as dangerous, considering the future generation, upon whom hopes are pinned to carry the banner of change and build the nation. What drives a student who acquires knowledge from universities to not show interest in exercising his legal rights and adhering to his duties? Here, we see that social and political upbringing plays a role in shaping these ideas, as if citizenship has been shaken, so to speak.

An individual may grow up in an environment that shapes their attitudes and inclinations. The circumstances in which they grow up, whether social, cultural, political, social, or economic, may influence their behavior and the way they exercise their rights and fulfill their duties. Political circumstances may also have played a significant role in shaping this outlook and adopting this stance, namely, a lack of interest, which clearly expresses a strongly worded position that cannot be surpassed by a thousand speeches. Abstention from political participation is a behavior that expresses a certain opinion, either resulting from a consciously taken

position or from a flaw in the individual's level of awareness of their role.

The results obtained from the study can also explain the sample's dissatisfaction with the prevailing situation, and it is possible that they reflect the reality that many societies are experiencing in our current era, where we tried to confirm this by asking the sample about their participation in the last elections, where the majority recorded the answer "no" at a rate of (73.6%), thus confirming the results of the previous question.

In this point Ryan Foote argues that, "Rather than viewing citizenship as a means to the realization of rights, we should view rights as a means to achieving equal citizenship. Achieving comprehensive development for active and equal citizenship for all requires the acquisition and actual exercise of citizenship rights, especially those related to the political sphere (Amenta, Nash, Scott, 2012, P 375).

In an attempt to identify the underlying reasons behind this reluctance to vote in the previous presidential elections, the sample's responses varied between not possessing a voter card, lack of trust in institutions, and lack of interest in the elections. This confirms the sample's position on election participation and their opinions about it. In an effort to correct this negative perception of elections and participation, we decided to ask the sample about factors that might encourage them to participate in the future. We recorded answers such as: "If there are young candidates," "If there is real change," "If there is transparency and credibility," "If there is freedom of expression and

opinion," "If it aligns with my political orientations," and "If there are genuine efforts to gain experience and encourage young people to participate politically."

Regarding the sample's knowledge of societal issues such as human rights, the environment, and public health, we recorded an average of 66%, while the remaining scores were similar. Regarding participation in community activities and initiatives, 41.5% reported a reluctance to participate, followed by the remaining answers, ranging from average (28.3%) to low (18.9%) and high (11.3%). Regarding interest in participating in political parties and civil society organizations with the aim of raising awareness, the degree of not interested was recorded at 47.2%, followed by the remaining degrees of interest at a medium degree at 28.3%, a low degree at 13.2%, and a high degree at 11.3%.

Relationship with Political Culture and Community play a crucial role to build political participation, the researches emphasize that social and political culture, community norms, and the social environment significantly influence participation levels and types, but operationalizing these factors remains complex for some societies.

Thus, the motivation for political participation consists of four basic concepts:

Political interest, which considers that citizens who are interested in and follow politics are more politically active; political information, which refers to knowledge of daily political events and actors; political efficacy, which refers to individuals' sense of the ability to influence the political process and their perceived qualifications; and political identity, which refers to the

strength of their ties to a particular policy. Through all of this, experiments have proven that internet use increases political interest and political efficacy (Tiemann-Kollipost, Pp 21-22).

A purely political" vision of citizenship, or more precisely, "participatory and democratic," must be activated. In this vision, politics involves "the collective and participatory participation of citizens in determining the affairs of their society," and we envision ourselves as "their spokespeople and actors" who participate in the public sphere. It emphasizes that only when active political participation is valued as an expression of citizenship, as opposed to the "politically sterile" concept of "the citizen as a mere bearer of rights. (Amenta, Nash, Scott, 2012, P 376).

In this point *"interest, information, efficacy, and partisan intensity provide the desire, knowledge, and self-assurance that impel people to be engaged in politics. But time, money, and skills provide the wherewithal without which engagement is meaningless"* (Tiemann-Kollipost, P 22).

**Hypothesis 03:** There are no significant differences in the impact of social media platforms on Algerian students' political participation.

Considering the indicators of the impact of social media on students' political participation, they were asked whether social media contributes to increasing their awareness of the importance of political participation. We recorded a divergence of opinion between those who believe it contributes moderately, not exceeding 47.2%, while there are those who believe it

contributes weakly, at 17%, and significantly, at 35.8%. From this, it becomes clear to us that the sample members do not see social media as an effective means of raising awareness of their roles, nor in terms of enhancing their political participation, in light of all the information, images, and videos published and spread, which sometimes discourages them and instils doubt in their souls about the importance of their roles. Regarding the role of these platforms in promoting a sense of social responsibility and participation, a moderate role was recorded for these platforms. This demonstrates that the social media platforms used by students are not focused on education and culture as much as they are on entertainment (this point was confirmed when the sample was asked about their use of social media in Section 2 of the questionnaire). This prompts us to investigate the reasons that drive students to subscribe to content that is devoid of substance and neglect that which would enhance their knowledge and skills.

As for the provision of reliable information on political issues by these platforms, the sample believes that the degree of credibility and reliability is moderate, as these platforms do not provide reliable information, especially with the widespread negative uses of artificial intelligence. For this reason, sample members do not always share political content on social media with family and friends, preferring to publish non-political content, and if available, it includes humanitarian issues and the Palestinian cause. To assess the role of these platforms in raising awareness and engaging students, half of the sample viewed their

contribution as moderate, while the other half oscillated between non-existent, weak, and high.

In this stage information is a key factor in the influence of online political participation on government policymaking. "The fundamental element underlying effective online engagement between citizens and governments is information". Since the emergence of the internet, especially social networking sites at the beginning of the 21st century, the number of internet users has grown rapidly. In addition, many new channels for online engagement have emerged that have influenced government agenda-setting. The main channels are online communities, microblogs, soft blogs, blogs, bulletin board systems, professional websites, and others, all of which have the potential to disseminate a large amount of information. Information quickly (Weng, 2018, Pp 62.63).

Consequently, the study sample is not convinced that social media platforms play a strong role in raising awareness and promoting engagement among students. This indicates that the predominant content published across various platforms does not address community awareness and does not highlight the importance of students' roles in effective community engagement. Regarding the risks of using social media in politics, the study sample believes that misleading public opinion is the greatest obstacle, followed by the rapid spread of fake news, which can sow confusion and influence ideas and behavior. This is followed by the spread of populist rhetoric and its growing use for purposes of discrimination, regional division, and hate

speech, especially given the lack of full oversight of biased content.

We can say in the end that political participation involves not only external actions but also internal cognitive attitudes, and perceptions which has a strong relation with human personalities. For example, changes in attitudes or beliefs may be as important as the practices and behaviors individuals exhibit, and our understanding of these internal processes is essential for interpreting the different patterns of participation that occur in society.

Finally, the effects of participation vary depending on the surrounding environment, and differences appear in patterns of participation in voluntary associations and elections, which may affect the nature and quality of participation.

#### 4. CONCLUSION

In fact, political participation has been influenced in the recent years by the explosion of technological transformations that have swept the world in general, and affecting political activity in particular where meanings and practices have been changed radically.

This shift at the political level has allowed for the emergence of a different type of political engagement, which researchers and thinkers have coined various terms, such as internet political participation, online political participation, or political participation via social media platforms.

As a result of this new phase, it was necessary to simplify political discussions to reach even those with less political knowledge or interest. This was necessary to ensure greater penetration of various segments of society, particularly youth, and



to encourage and motivate them to participate politically, express themselves, make their voices and demands heard, and enable them to become active participants in online engagement activities.

However, online participation often remains elusive due to several considerations, such as the intolerance and intellectual closure suffered by some individuals, and their refusal to engage in political dialogue and debate. This is the greatest obstacle to changing mindsets toward accepting constructive political participation via social media. This has the potential to significantly influence young people and discourage them from engaging in these new forms of participation. The means of expanding the scope of this political participation remain tied to algorithms, platform development, and political marketing strategies that are consistent with the social and political specificities that vary with the diversity of societies. Without this, the transition to achieving the desired development remains somewhat complex in light of current realities.

The study concluded with a set of findings, the most important of which are:

- Ensuring the impact of social media platforms on the opinions of Algerian youth, so that the study revealed that these platforms have an impact on students' opinions, behaviors and attitudes, an impact ranging from moderate and large, according to the sample opinions by 54.7 %
- The study sample includes a highly important and dangerous demographic sample at the same time, so that the main axis of study is university students between the ages of 18 and 25

years, as this group is one of the most difficult categories in order to be subject to the fact that it is subject to intellectual, cognitive and even cognitive fluctuations, for that it was classified as dangerous and a critical stage of intellectual and civil maturity if it is better directed, and therefore it can be considered, and therefore it can be considered, Student category as the most vulnerable category to the effect of these digital platforms.

- Continuous and continuous exposure to social media leads to an increase in the possibility of influence: According to the results reached after field research procedures on a sample of Algerian students, the average daily use of these platforms exceeded four hours for many students, which may increase the possibility of changing students' ideas and behaviors.
- Facebook platform is the basic means of influence: so that, according to the field study, Facebook is the most interactive and interactive platform by students at the Faculty of Media Science at the University of Algeria 3, which makes it the most important platform that contributes to the formation of students' opinions.
- The multi Role of Social Media: social media plays a pivotal role from many sides positively and negatively, for example; social media could be the primary source of information, interaction among people, even for learning. either could be the source of misinformation and disinformation.
- The increase of cyber space challenges ; where anyone can choose the identity he wants without any

control, this will enhance the chance for using what is known as "the digital mask" which can lead to create distorted facts and make students unable to understand it.

- according to the study sample citizenship is Perceived as Rights-Bearing, Not Participatory: The data suggests that students view citizenship more as a status that confers rights ("citizen as a mere bearer of rights") rather than an identity that requires active political engagement ("participatory and democratic" vision) and this is the core problem.
- Low participation rates in civic and political institutions: The results show a clear reluctance among the sample to participate in formal political and civic structures, not to mention a lack of desire. 47.2% of students indicated they were unwilling to join political parties or civil society organizations.
- Average sense of duty, with severe aversion among university students: According to the results obtained, 54.7% of students believe they exercise their rights and duties at an average level, while the remaining percentage believes they do not perform their duties as required. This contrasts sharply with the 73.6% aversion to participating in the last elections, confirming a significant gap in the mindset of the study sample. This demonstrates a real gap that requires solutions: the gap between ideas and actions.

### 5. Recommendations and suggestions

Improving university student participation does not happen overnight, nor does it happen by wishful thinking.

Rather, it happens through hard, persistent work that requires the combined efforts of all parties. To this end, we have formulated a set of proposals and recommendations, which are:

- ✓ It is necessary to work on incorporating digital literacy curricula, as illiteracy today no longer includes only those who cannot read and write, but extends to all those who are unable to use digital tools. This is in keeping with global developments. Therefore, it is necessary to teach students how to deal with misleading content and verify information sources.
- ✓ Work on awareness-raising efforts, as universities have become a strategic platform for enlightening ideas and educating students about what is circulating on social media platforms. It is also necessary to educate them about the risks of indiscriminate and prolonged use of these platforms and applications.
- ✓ Encourage academic and scientific discussions that stimulate critical analysis of electronic content, particularly among undergraduate and master's students, and even those at the doctoral level.
- ✓ Educate students to promote a culture of verification before sharing, especially regarding sensitive and controversial topics and issues, as the indiscriminate publication and sharing of trivial or misleading content may increase its popularity and spread. It is also necessary to emphasize that virtual presence does not alone constitute an individual's identity, but must be coupled with real-life discussions.

- ✓ Helping young leaders with transparency and credibility assume leadership positions in political parties and official institutions will change the perception of the role of youth in politics and society.
- ✓ The need to change prevailing concepts that focus on every right being accompanied by a duty, and to incorporate more influential and robust concepts such as citizenship, participation, peaceful deliberation, political openness, and critical political participation.
- ✓ Encouraging students to begin with community engagement as a fundamental pillar of political participation, such as clean-up campaigns and health awareness campaigns, which do not entail formal obligations or significant responsibilities, followed by gradual and effective engagement at other levels.
- ✓ Integrating efforts between university institutions and governmental and non-governmental organizations to organize study days and workshops to teach young people and university students communication and public speaking skills, facilitating their participation in various organizations.
- ✓ Amplify Student Voices: Create more university-based forums, student unions, and partnerships with local government where students can see their input leading to tangible outcomes, thereby strengthening their "political efficacy."

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